

SUSPECTS GALLERY Youth arrested and stolen phones recovered after a raid in Sikri village, Deeg, Aug. 24

49.48
ILLICIT CASH IN RUPEES LAKHS SEIZED FROM CRIMINALS IN DEEG

5,029
DROP IN NUMBER OF CYBERCRIME CASES ARISING FROM DEEG, FROM FEBRUARY TO AUGUST 2024

programme of sorts where fraudsters would get "trained" at other centres. So, Arif, alias Bablu, 32, spent six months with Meena to master how to procure forged SIM cards and then learnt how to handle stolen mobile phones from Asif, alias Kallu, of Tughlaqabad, Delhi. Arif himself set up his gang after a spell of training in Jamtara and has sold around 10,000 stolen mobile phones.

PIECING TOGETHER THE PUZZLE

Behind these arrests has been the systematic execution of Operation Anti Virus. Using complaints of cyber frauds originating in Deeg and registered across India, Prakash and his team have created a directory of the phone locations of suspects at the police station level. A dedicated cyber technical team in a war room tracks these phones and other digital footprints of the suspects. This list is constantly updated, with suspects identified according to their specialisation: providers of forged/ fake SIM cards, bank accounts, ATM cards and mule accounts; those who carry out sextortion; regular online fraudsters; installers/ operators of ATM machines who are hand in glove with cyber thugs and those who impersonate police officers/ officials to coerce people. The team also analyses the active location of cellphones used by suspected criminals daily through the Centre's Pratibimb portal. They match these with the earlier addresses/ locations in the station-wise directory and finally hone in on the exact places to raid. Typically, during a raid at a place from where the fraud calls originate, the police seizes mobile phones, scans phones for fraud calls, suspicious transactions and incriminating chats, and searches the place/ persons for fake SIM cards, forged documents and changed IMEIs. Suspects are booked for these crimes and FIRs are registered for child pornography and cyberterrorism.

After confiscating suspicious/ illegal objects, the probe team analyses material like stolen mobile phones, fake SIMs, fake bank accounts and payment screenshots. A detailed analysis of IMEI/ SIM sets the police on to the spoor of other criminals. In places where complaints on helpline number 1930 have not led to FIRs being lodged, the superintendents of police are asked to record statements of victims to build watertight cases. The team under Prakash has made online fraud an extremely costly act. The deterrent is not just jail time, but also confiscation/ destruction of properties built on government land using proceeds of fraud money—though the recent Supreme Court strictures may now curb this. Saad had four shops demolished on June 11, and Prakash has ordered the demolition of a 2,000 sq. feet house in Raipur Suketi, said to be built with Rs 70 lakh by gangster Dawood, who has been absconding since 2021. His gang of 12 operated from and shared their pelf from here.

THE UNFINISHED AGENDA

Much of the challenge before the police in meting out strict punishment to cyber criminals operating out of Deeg comes from legal loopholes. Since most of the fraudsters target victims in other states, police from those states mostly don't bother pursuing them; in any case, finding suspects in a short time in a different area is difficult. Besides, many complaints lodged on 1930 do not convert into FIRs.

But one of the main roadblocks is that of bail. Cyber criminals often get bail easily as FIRs are registered under fraud, which attracts milder punishment. And because bail is obtained easily, recidivism is rampant. To remedy the situation, police officers hold coordination meetings with judges, where they convey the seriousness and enormity of cybercrime. Comprehensive police reports—with details of the 1930 complaint, the seizure of incriminating material, evidence found in the phone, its impact at the national level, minors involved and the development of a criminal environment in the area—are going a long way towards not letting off criminals on bail quickly.

Prakash is confident that the cumulative effect of longer imprisonment, along with targeted demolition of property and seizure of assets, has hit the morale of criminals and proved an effective deterrent. Trouble is, one Deeg may be freed of cyber criminals, but many more may take root. ■